



TRANSFER VS. STAY **DECISION FRAMEWORK**

Financial Modeling, Career Outcome Comparisons,
and a Structured Framework for the Biggest Decision of Law
School

IvyAmbition

T14 Law School Admissions Consulting



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CHAPTER 01

Why This Decision Is Harder Than It Looks

You got into a T-14 as a transfer. Congratulations. Now comes the hardest part: deciding whether to go. This sounds absurd — why wouldn't you? But the decision is more nuanced than most students realize, and making it purely on prestige is a **six-figure financial mistake** for some applicants.

The variables: scholarship money you're giving up, full tuition you'll pay, career outcome differentials, geographic preferences, social costs, and opportunity costs. Students who evaluate all of these make better decisions than students who just chase the highest-ranked name.

→ **THE PRINCIPLE:** Transfer when the expected career outcome differential exceeds the financial cost by a meaningful margin. Stay when the cost exceeds the differential, or when non-financial factors strongly favor your current school.

CHAPTER 02

The Financial Model

Build a spreadsheet with these exact numbers:

1 Cost of Staying

Tuition for 2L and 3L at current school, minus your scholarship. Add living expenses. This is your baseline.

2 Cost of Transferring

Full tuition for 2L and 3L at the new school (assume no scholarship unless you have one in writing), plus moving costs, plus new-city living expenses. Subtract any transfer scholarship offered.

3

The Gap

Subtract cost of staying from cost of transferring. This is your **transfer premium** — the additional money you're paying for the T-14 degree. Typical range: \$60,000 to \$180,000.

EXAMPLE CALCULATION

Staying: \$50K tuition × 2 years = \$100K, minus \$60K scholarship = **\$40K total**

Transferring: \$75K tuition × 2 years = \$150K, minus \$0 scholarship = **\$150K total**

Transfer premium: \$150K – \$40K = **\$110,000**

The question: will the T-14 degree generate \$110K+ more in career value?

CHAPTER 03

The Career Outcome Comparison

Look up both schools' ABA employment data. The numbers that matter:

1

BigLaw + Federal Clerkship Rate

This is the single most important metric for students targeting high-paying legal careers. T-14 schools range from 50-80%. Schools ranked 20-50 range from 10-40%. The gap is enormous and directly translates to expected income.

2

Median Private Sector Salary

If both schools place into BigLaw, the starting salary is identical (\$225K). The difference is **probability of getting there**, not the salary itself.

3

Employment Score at 10 Months

What percentage of graduates have full-time, long-term, JD-required employment? This captures outcomes across all career paths, not just BigLaw.

The Expected Value Calculation

If your current school places 25% into BigLaw and the T-14 places 65%, the transfer increases your BigLaw probability by 40 percentage points. At \$225K starting salary vs a non-BigLaw average of ~\$75K, the expected income increase is roughly \$60K/year for at least 3-5 years. Over 5 years, that's **\$300K in expected additional earnings** — well above most transfer premiums.

★ **BUT:** If you're already top 10% at your current school, your individual BigLaw probability is much higher than your school's average. Top 10% at a T-30 might have 60-70% BigLaw odds already. In that case, the transfer premium buys you less marginal improvement.

CHAPTER 04

The Non-Financial Factors

1 Geographic Preference

If you want to practice in NYC and you're choosing between a T-14 in NYC and a strong regional school in the Midwest, the T-14 makes geographic sense beyond just prestige. If your current school is already in your target market, the geographic advantage of transferring is smaller.

2 Network and Alumni Base

A T-14 degree gives you access to a national alumni network. If your career goals require national mobility, this matters. If you plan to practice in your current school's home market, your local network may be equally valuable.

3 Social Cost

You've built friendships, study groups, and a reputation at your current school. Transferring means starting over socially as a 2L. Some students handle this easily. Others find it isolating. Be honest with yourself about where you fall.

4

Academic Opportunities

Specific clinics, journals, faculty, or programs that only exist at the transfer school. If you have a niche interest that your current school can't support, this is a strong non-financial reason to transfer.

5

Clerkship Pipeline

If you're targeting federal clerkships, T-14 placement rates are dramatically higher. Some circuits and judges hire almost exclusively from T-14 schools. If clerkships are your goal, this alone may justify the transfer.

CHAPTER 05

The Decision Matrix

Score each factor 1-5 for both options. Weight the factors based on your priorities. The school with the higher weighted score is your answer.

Factor	Weight	Current School	Transfer School
BigLaw/Clerkship probability	_____	_____/5	_____/5
Total cost (lower = better)	_____	_____/5	_____/5
Geographic fit	_____	_____/5	_____/5
Specific academic programs	_____	_____/5	_____/5
Alumni network strength	_____	_____/5	_____/5
Social/personal fit	_____	_____/5	_____/5
Clerkship pipeline	_____	_____/5	_____/5
Scholarship/financial aid	_____	_____/5	_____/5

→ **HOW TO USE:** Assign weights (1-3) based on your priorities. Score each school 1-5 per factor. Multiply weight × score for each row. Sum the columns. The higher total is your data-driven answer. This doesn't make the decision for you, but it forces you to be honest about your priorities.

CHAPTER 06

When to Stay

Transferring is not always the right call. Here are the cases where staying is the stronger move:

1 Large Scholarship at Risk

If you have a full or near-full scholarship and the T-14 offers nothing, you're paying \$150K+ for the name change. If you're already top 10% at your current school with strong BigLaw odds, the math often favors staying.

2 Regional Career Goals

If you want to practice in your current school's home market and that school has strong local placement, the T-14 national brand may not add enough value to justify the cost.

3 Top of Your Class Benefits

Being #1 at your current school has real advantages: law review editor, best faculty relationships, top employers at OCI recruiting from your school specifically. Being middle of the pack at a T-14 may not be better.

4 Personal Circumstances

Family obligations, a partner's career, health considerations, or other personal factors that make relocation impractical or harmful. No ranking is worth sacrificing your wellbeing.

5

Public Interest with Strong LRAP

If your current school has a generous LRAP and you're committed to public interest, transferring to pay full tuition at a T-14 without guaranteed LRAP coverage could leave you worse off financially for a decade.

NEED HELP WITH YOUR TRANSFER DECISION?

IvyAmbition offers Transfer Decision Sessions where we run the numbers, compare outcomes, and help you make the call with confidence.

Book a free 15-minute consultation at ivyambition.com